

A'l - Imran : V:104

وَلْتَكُنْ مِنْكُمْ أُمَّةٌ يَدْعُونَ إِلَى الْخَيْرِ وَيَأْمُرُونَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَيَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ ۚ وَأُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْمُفْلِحُونَ ﴿١٠٤﴾ (آل عمران: 104)

Explanation

- **Context:** In the **previous verses (102 - 103)**, Muslims were given two principles which guarantee their collective well-being. If everyone practiced **Taqwa** and made Islam his linkage with Allah (**Holding the Cord of Allah**),-the result will be that individual life will be corrected and the collective strength of Muslims will come in its wake.
- **In the present verse (104)**, yet another dimension of the proposed system has been added. It has been said here that Muslims are not to rest at the correction of what they think and do individually; but they should, along with that, **be affectionately concerned with the good of other brothers and sisters in faith**. By doing so, the whole community shall have the benefit of keeping its stance correct at all times, and at the same time, this will guarantee closer mutual cooperation and unity.
- **Collective well-being of Muslims depends on two things:** These are:
 - 1** Self-correction through Taqwa and a firm hold on the 'cord of Allah' through the Qur'an and the Faith.
 - 2** The correction of others through call (da'wah) and positive propagation.
- Then comes another level of this function - that there be a dedicated group among Muslims devoted exclusively to the mission of calling people to the Faith and giving them right guidance towards it.
- **The first part of the verse** translated as (And there has to be a group of people from among you) gives a hint that the presence of this group is necessary. In case, a government does not shoulder this responsibility, it will become obligatory on Muslims that they should establish and operate such a group, because the vital role of the *Ummah* depends on the existence of such a group.
- **What are the major features of this group?** The Quranic answer is: **يَدْعُونَ إِلَى الْخَيْرِ** (who call towards the good). It means that this call of theirs shall be their primary objective. What does 'khayr' or 'good' mean? The Holy Prophet has himself explained it by saying that **'khayr'** means following the Quran and my Sunnah. (Ibn Kathir)
- in the beginning makes it clear; that the function of this group will be to call towards the good, even when evil practices are not seen, **or** time may not have come to perform something obligatory.
- this 'call towards good' has two sub-levels: **1)** Calling non-Muslims towards 'khayr', that is, Islam. This involves all Muslims. It means that every Muslim, in general, and this group, in particular, is responsible for giving the call of Islam, both by words and acts, to

all peoples of the world. **2)** The second sub-level of this noble function is to call Muslims themselves towards the good. Again this second call takes two forms as: **a)** The first form will be that of a general and open call to good through which all Muslims will be educated into necessary injunctions and morals which have to be followed in Islam, **b)** The second call would be particular and selective through which the objective will be to produce experts in the Muslim community, experts in the sciences of the Qur'an and the Sunnah.

- Further on, this responsibility-bearing group has been identified as carrying the additional distinction of **وَيَأْمُرُونَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَيَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ**, that is, 'they bid the Fair and forbid the Unfair'.
- The word Maaruf literally means 'recognized,' it includes all good enjoined by Islam, and promoted by all prophets during their respective ages. Since what is good is known and recognized, it has been referred to as 'ma'rif. similarly, the word, 'munkar' literally means 'non-recognized' or "alien", but as a Qur'anic term it includes all evils and disorders about which it is well-known and recognized that the Holy Prophet declared them to be impermissible.
- Towards the conclusion of the verse, the commendable end of the group described therein has been enshrined in the following words: **وَأُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْمُفْلِحُونَ** It simply means that, in reality, success is achieved by such people alone.

A'l - Imran : V:110

كُنْتُمْ خَيْرَ أُمَّةٍ أُخْرِجَتْ لِلنَّاسِ تَأْمُرُونَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَتَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ وَتُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ وَلَوْ آمَنَ أَهْلُ الْكِتَابِ لَكَانَ خَيْرًا لَهُمْ ۚ مِنْهُمْ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ وَأَكْثَرُ هُمُ الْفَاسِقُونَ ﴿١١٠﴾ (آل عمران: 110)

Explanation

- **Context:** In previous verses, Muslims were asked to take special care in order to remain steadfast in their faith, bid the Fair and forbid the Unfair. In the present verse, it has been further emphasized that these are the very reasons why Allah Almighty has conferred upon the Ummah of Muhammad, may the peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, the status of 'Khayr al-Umam', the best of communities, dignified and elevated, when it does what it has been charged to do.
- **Why the best of communities?** In this particular verse, another reason has been given. The reason is that this community has been raised for the sole purpose of dispensing good to all beings created by Allah. It has been actually charged with the function of remaining concerned with their spiritual and moral reformation. Seen in the perspective of past communities, it was this community which contributed most in the mission of 'bidding

the Fair and forbidding the Unfair', even though this was already enjoined upon past communities as mentioned in authentic *ahadith*.

- **The second distinguishing feature** of this community is that they 'believe in Allah': **وَتُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ** At this point one may ask why should this be a distinguishing feature of the Muslim community as belief in Allah has been the common factor between all past prophets and their communities. The answer is clear. No doubt, belief as such is common to all, but the degrees of perfection in belief differ. **The degree of preference given to the community of Muhammad** (SAWW) has a class of its own as compared to past communities.
- The meaning of the **Ayah اُخْرِجْتُ لِلنَّاسِ** is that the **Ummah** of Muhammad is the most **righteous and beneficial nation** for mankind. Hence Allah's description of them, **تَأْمُرُونَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَتَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ وَتُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ**
Ahmad, At-Tirmidhi, Ibn Majah, and Al-Hakim recorded that Hakim bin Muawiyah bin Haydah narrated that his father said **that the Messenger of Allah said, "You are the final of seventy nations, you are the best and most honored among them to Allah"**. This is a well-known **Hadith** about which At-Tirmidhi said, "Hasan", and which is also narrated from Mu'adh bin Jabal and Abu Sa'id.
- **The Ummah of Muhammad achieved this virtue because of its Prophet**, Muhammad, peace be upon him, the most regarded of Allah's creation and the most honored Messenger with Allah. Allah sent Muhammad with the perfect and complete Law that was never given to any Prophet or Messenger before him.
- For instance, **Imam Ahmad recorded that Ali bin Abi Talib said, "The Messenger of Allah said, I was given what no other Prophet before me was given. We said, 'O Messenger of Allah! What is it?' He said, I was given victory by fear, I was given the keys of the earth, I was called Ahmad, the earth was made a clean place for me (to pray and perform Tayammum with it), and my Ummah was made the best Ummah."** The chain of narration for this **Hadith** is Hasan.
- **Imam Ahmad recorded that Buraydah said that; the Prophet said, "The people of Paradise are one hundred and twenty rows, this Ummah takes up eighty of them"**. Imam Ahmad also collected this **Hadith** through another chain of narration. At-Tirmidhi and Ibn Majah also collected this **Hadith**, and At-Tirmidhi said, this **Hadith** is Hasan.
- **Abdur-Razzaq recorded that Abu Hurayrah said that, the Prophet said: "We (Muslims) are the last to come, but the foremost on the Day of Resurrection, and the first people to enter Paradise, although the former nations were given the Scriptures before us and we after them. Allah gave us the guidance of truth that they have been disputing about. This (Friday) is the Day that they have been disputing about, and**

all the other people are behind us in this matter: the Jews' (day of congregation is) tomorrow (Saturday) and the Christians' is the day after tomorrow (Sunday)”.

- These and other **Hadiths** conform to the meaning of the **Ayah** “You are the best of peoples ever raised up for mankind; you enjoin **Al-Ma`ruf** (all that Islam has ordained) and forbid **Al-Munkar** (all that Islam has forbidden), and you believe in Allah) Therefore, whoever among this **Ummah** acquires these qualities, will have a share in this praise.

Qatadah said, "We were told that Umar bin Al-Khattab recited this **Ayah** (3:110) during a **Hajj** that he performed, when he saw that the people were rushing. He then said, "Whoever likes to be among this (praised) **Ummah**, let him fulfill the condition that Allah set in this **Ayah**."

- Ibn Jarir recorded this. **Those from this Ummah who do not acquire these qualities will be just like the People of the Scriptures whom Allah criticized.** This is the reason why, after Allah praised the Muslim **Ummah** with the qualities that He mentioned, He criticized the People of the Scriptures and chastised them, saying, **وَلَوْ آمَنَ أَهْلُ الْكِتَابِ لَكَانَ خَيْرًا لَهُمْ مِنْهُمْ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ وَأَكْثَرُهُمُ الْفَاسِقُونَ**. Towards the end of the verse, it has been said about the people of the Book that there are some Muslims among them. This refers to those who had confirmed the prophet hood of our Holy Prophet & such as, Sayyidna 'Abdullah ibn Salam and others.

ادْعُ إِلَى سَبِيلِ رَبِّكَ بِالْحُكْمَةِ وَالْمَوْعِظَةِ الْحَسَنَةِ ۚ وَجَادِلْهُمْ بِالَّتِي هِيَ أَحْسَنُ ۚ إِنَّ رَبَّكَ هُوَ أَعْلَمُ بِمَنْ ضَلَّ عَنْ سَبِيلِهِ ۚ وَهُوَ أَعْلَمُ بِالْمُهْتَدِينَ ﴿١٢٥﴾ (النحل:125)

Explanation:

- **Da'wah and Tabligh: Principles and Curriculum:** Embedded in this verse (125) there lies a whole curriculum of Da'wah and Tabligh, its principles and rules of etiquette, within the frame of a few words.
- Literally, **da'wah**, means to call. The first duty of the blessed prophets is to call people towards Allah.
- Calling people towards Allah (da'wah ilal-lah) has been made obligatory on the Muslim Ummah following in the footsteps of the Holy Prophet (SAWW) (**see reference verse no 104 above**).
- While expressing the general sense, **إِلَى سَبِيلِ رَبِّكَ** this word may take several forms, such as: (dawah ilal-lah: Calling towards Allah), (da'wah ila al-khair: Calling toward the good) and (da'wah ila sabi llallah: Calling towards the way of Allah), the outcome is the

same because calling towards Allah is actually calling towards His din and the Straight Path.

- The next phrase رَبَّكَ : (ila sabili rabbik: to the way of your Lord) carries two nuances of expression. Here, by mentioning the special attribute of the Most Exalted Allah - 'Rabb' - and then by annexing it to the Holy Prophet (saw), a hint has been given that the work of Da'wah is connected with the attribute of nurture, raising, training and education.
- **The expression:** بِالْحِكْمَةِ (bil-hikmah: with wisdom) which follows immediately has been used 'in the Holy Qur'an for several meanings. Here it means: the Qur' an, the Faith, a binding argument, "It is sound speech which goes into one's heart" (Ruh al-Ma'ani), and "Al-Hikmah means the insight through which one finds out the dictates of circumstances and talks as appropriate relatively, chooses such time and occasion as would not put a burden on the addressee, employs lenience where lenience is called for and firmness where firmness is in order. And where he thinks the addressee would be embarrassed by saying something frankly, there he should use hints to communicate, or employ a change of subject and approach in a way that neither embarrasses the addressee nor feeds him with the thought of sticking by his prejudice." (Ruh al Bayan)
- The next word: وَالْمَوْعِظَةِ literally means to say something in the spirit of wishing well in a manner that would make the heart of the addressee softened and arable, all tuned to accept it. Once this is done, it will be useful to talk about the reward and benefit of such acceptance, as well as, about the punishment and ill-effects of not accepting it.
- Later, by saying الْحَسَنَةِ (good), the sense conveyed is that the subject and treatment of this counsel should be such as would satisfy the heart of the addressee, removing doubts and apprehensions whereby the addressee comes to realize that you have no personal motive behind your approach and that you are addressing him only in the interest of the addressee and for his or her good.
- The word: جَادِلْهُمْ (argue) in the subsequent sentence: وَجَادِلْهُمْ بِالَّتِي هِيَ أَحْسَنُ (And argue with them in the best of manners) means that should there be, in the process of Da'wah, the need to engage in debate or exchange of arguments then, that discussion should also be in the best of manners.
- Good Manners require a gentle and soft approach in mutual submissions, arguments have to be such as would be easily understood by the addressee, arguments have to be supported by known premises so that they help remove the doubts of the addressee and shields him against falling into dogmatism.

- **The Prophet (SAWW) said:** "Do not learn the '*ilm* (of *din*) to compete with the learned in pride and prestige nor to challenge the incompetent with it nor to make the faces of people turn towards you therewith. So whoever will do that, will be in the fire." (Ibn Majah)
- **Imam Malik (R.A.) said:** "Imam Malik said: "Altercation and confrontation in *al-'ilm* (the knowledge of *din*) drives away the light of knowledge from the heart of a servant." Someone submitted: 'There is a person. who has the knowledge of Sunnah. Can he enter into debate for the protection of Sunnah?' He said, "No. But, he should inform the addressee about the Sunnah (as it is). Then, should he accept it, good - otherwise, let him observe silence" (al-Muwatta)
- After that, **the last part of verse 125** إِنَّ رَبَّكَ هُوَ أَعْلَمُ بِمَنْ ضَلَّ عَنْ سَبِيلِهِ ۖ وَهُوَ أَعْلَمُ بِالْمُنْتَدِينَ
Therefore, in this sentence, it was said: 'Your duty is only to invite people to the Truth in accordance with its correct principles. Beyond that, its acceptance or rejection is something you have nothing to do with, nor is that one of your responsibilities. That falls in the domain of Allah alone. He knows who will remain astray and who will stand guided. You should not worry about it. Go on doing your duty. Do not lose hope. Do not despair.' This tells us that this sentence too is really a complement of the etiquette of Da'wah.